

NANDAN DAVE

BEASTS OF BURDEN
Stray cattle blocking traffic on a highway in Ahmedabad, Feb. 17

On January 20, as Gujarat agriculture minister Raghavji Patel arrived at a *gaushala* in Morbi, a bull—all decked-up—was readied for a special ceremony. During the short *puja* that followed, the minister showered the bovine with flowers, seeking blessings for what was to come... The unsuspecting bull was soon to become the first to be castrated as part of a statewide drive to—as Patel described it—"conserve stray cattle".

The BJP government in Gujarat finds itself in an uncomfortable quandary in dealing with an excess of bovines. So, it has decided to castrate 50,000-odd bulls that are over a year old. This is the latest in a series of failed attempts to curb the stray cattle menace in the state's urban areas. Abandoned or left loose in public spaces, cattle—especially bulls—continue to pose a threat to humans, attacking passers-by or causing road accidents. In August last year, even former deputy chief minister Nitin Patel suffered a minor leg fracture after a stray cow charged through a BJP rally he was leading in Mehsana district. At times, such mishaps turn fatal—on January 24, just four days after the castration drive was launched, a man was killed after he rammed his car into a stray bull in Bhavnagar. It has been over a year since the Gujarat High Court first took cognisance of the issue and has been continuously nudging the government to "act", noting in December last year that the "stray cattle menace has gone out of proportion".

The birthplace of the white revolution, Gujarat accounts for 7.75 per cent of India's milk production. One would imagine its teeming cattle—5 per cent of the country's total—would complement this booming industry that is estimated to be worth around Rs 1 lakh crore, nearly a fourth of the state's agricultural GDP. It's not as if the cattle numbers have gone up in the past decade. In fact, between 2012 and 2019, they came down from 9.98 million to 9.63 million, a drop of 3.5 per cent, according to the latest livestock surveys. However, rapid urbanisation, combined with farming mechanisation and cow protection activism, has turned bovines, especially bulls that account for about a fifth of the cattle population, into a burden—so much so that the stray cattle numbers surged by 17.5 per cent, from 292,462 to 343,918, in the same period.

That said, the issue is hardly limited to Gujarat: the stray cattle menace is rampant across India, but more apparent in BJP-ruled states, such as Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, where cow protection—pushed by both anti-slaughter legislation and vigilantism—has led to the problem of plenty. In UP, for instance, *awara pashu* or *chhutta janwar*—as they are called colloquially—became a major poll issue ahead of the assembly election last February. As the Opposition upped the ante, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had to step in and promise a new policy to deal with the issue after the election result.

Gujarat had its own share of the brouhaha over stray cattle ahead of the assembly election in December, due to a proposed legislation that aimed to curb the menace across its towns and cities. With nearly 45 per cent of its population living in urban areas, the state prides itself on being among the most urbanised in the country. But it has come at a cost for the livestock, which has lost both its habitation and grazing land. Take, for instance, Ahmedabad, the largest city in Gujarat and the seventh-largest urban agglomeration in India. "In 2021, 38 villages were merged into the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (MC) for urban development," says Nagji Desai, president of the Maldhari Mahapanchayat—the council of the cattle-rearing community. "But essentially these are still villages, inhabited by farmers and livestock rearers."

But all of a sudden, in April last year, what was their home was proposed to be turned into a restricted territory for their livestock when the Gujarat Cattle Control (Keeping and Moving) in Urban Areas Bill, 2022, was introduced in the assembly. As the name suggests, it aimed to regulate the movement of loose cattle in urban areas and penalise the errant owners. Because this was an election year, the bill was withdrawn under pressure from the Maldhari community—which makes up about 10 per cent of the state's population. But facing the HC's